

CHAPTER 3

Movies: See De Vany (2002). See also Salganik et al. (2006) for the contagion in music buying.

Religion and domains of contagion: See Boyer (2001).

Wisdom (madness) of crowds: Collectively, we can both get wiser or far more foolish. We may collectively have intuitions for Mediocristan-related matters, such as the weight of an ox (see Surowiecki, 2004), but my conjecture is that we fail in more complicated predictions (economic variables for which crowds incur pathologies—two heads are worse than one). For decision errors and groups, see Sniezek and Buckley (1993). Classic: Charles Mackay's *Extraordinary Popular Delusions and the Madness of Crowds*.

Increase in the severity of events: Zajdenweber (2000).

Modern life: The nineteenth-century novelist Émile Zola welcomed the arrival of the market for culture in the late 1800s, of which he seemed to be one of the first beneficiaries. He predicted that the writers' and artists' ability to exploit the commercial system freed them from a dependence on patrons' whims. Alas, this was accompanied with more severe concentration—very few people benefited from the system. Lahire (2006) shows how most writers, throughout history, have starved. Remarkably, we have ample data from France about the literary tradition.